

Trust in Translation

Repairing Misunderstandings with Warmth and Clarity



Name: _____

Date: _____

Activity 1: Podcast Reflection Guide

Use this guide while listening to the podcast, then reflect on how the strategies could support your own workplace communication.

Part 1: During the Podcast

As you listen, pay attention to:

- *what creates tension or confusion*
- *what signals show the message did not land clearly*
- *how tone, pacing, or phrasing affects the interaction*
- *what repair language helps restore clarity*
- *what changes after the repair*



Interaction 1: Asking for Clarification

1. What caused the misunderstanding?

2. What clues showed that something was off?

3. What did Cemre do differently in the repaired version?

4. What effect did that change have?



Part 1: During the Podcast

As you listen, pay attention to:

- *what creates tension or confusion*
- *what signals show the message did not land clearly*
- *how tone, pacing, or phrasing affects the interaction*
- *what repair language helps restore clarity*
- *what changes after the repair*

Interaction 2: Feedback That Feels Like Criticism

1. What made Tomas's first comment feel difficult to receive?

2. How did Cemre respond?

3. How did Tomas repair the moment?

4. What language or tone helped make the conversation feel more collaborative?



Part 1: During the Podcast

As you listen, pay attention to:

- *what creates tension or confusion*
- *what signals show the message did not land clearly*
- *how tone, pacing, or phrasing affects the interaction*
- *what repair language helps restore clarity*
- *what changes after the repair*

Interaction 3: Delayed Repair

1. What signs suggested there was lingering tension?

2. Why do you think Cemre did not address it right away?

3. What made Tomas's delayed repair effective?

4. What did this moment show about trust?

Language to Borrow

As you listen, write down any phrase you might want to use in your own conversations.

- Phrase 1: _____
- Phrase 2: _____
- Phrase 3: _____

Part 2: Reflect After Listening



Take a few moments to think about what stood out to you.

- Which interaction felt most realistic or familiar to you? Why?
- What did you notice about the role of tone, pacing, or body language?
- Which repair phrase felt most natural or effective to you?
- What helped the repaired versions feel clearer, warmer, or more respectful?
- What is one idea from the podcast that you want to remember?

Write a quick reflection on those ideas:

Complete the sentence:

One thing I learned about repairing misunderstandings is:

Part 3: After the Podcast

Connect it to your own workplace

Think of a time when your message did not land the way you intended, or when you misunderstood someone else.

- What was the situation?
- How did you notice something had gone wrong?
- What verbal or non-verbal signals stood out?
- How did you respond?
- What might you do differently now?

Try a Repair: *If a similar situation happened again, what could you say?*

My repair phrase:

How I would want to say it (tone/body language):

My Practice Goal

In my next workplace conversation, I will try to:

- Notice: _____
- Say: _____
- Adjust: _____

ACTIVITY 2:

Team Communication Reflection Prompts

As a small group or team, discuss a set of guided prompts. This can be done in pairs, small groups, or as a full-team debrief.

Instructions

Use the prompts below to reflect on how communication works in your team. Focus on curiosity, not blame. The goal is to better understand one another and identify simple ways to make communication clearer and more supportive.

Discussion prompts can include:

- What helps you feel clear, respected, and included in workplace conversations?
- What kinds of misunderstandings happen most often on teams like yours?
- What are some common signs that a message has not landed as intended?
- How do people usually respond when there is tension or confusion?
- What helps feedback feel constructive rather than critical?
- What makes it easier to ask for clarification?
- How do tone, pacing, body language, or word choice affect communication in your team?
- How do cultural or personal communication differences show up in your workplace?
- What is one thing teammates can do to create more clarity during difficult conversations?
- What is one thing your team could practice more often to repair misunderstandings early?

ACTIVITY 2:

Team Communication Reflection Prompts

Write a reflection on what was discussed (try to answer 3-4 prompts minimum)

ACTIVITY 3:

Misunderstanding Prevention Plan

Use the following plan to reduce misunderstandings

1. Situations where misunderstandings are most likely to happen for me:

Examples: giving feedback, virtual meetings, written messages, fast-paced conversations, conversations across language or cultural differences

2. Early signs that a misunderstanding may be happening:

Examples: silence, defensiveness, hesitation, short answers, awkward pauses, confusion

3. What I tend to do when communication starts to break down:

ACTIVITY 3:

Misunderstanding Prevention Plan

Use the following plan to reduce misunderstandings

4. What I want to do instead:

5. Repair phrases I want to practice:

-
-
-

6. Non-verbal habits I want to be more aware of:

Examples: tone, facial expression, pacing, posture, eye contact

7. One commitment I want to make for future conversations:

Key Message

Misunderstandings are a normal part of workplace communication. Even when your words are clear to you, tone, pacing, body language, and cultural differences can affect how your message is received.

What matters most is not avoiding every misunderstanding. It is knowing how to notice when communication has gone off track and how to repair it with warmth, clarity, and respect.

What You Learned

In this lesson, you explored how to:

- recognize when your message has not landed as intended
- use repair language to clarify meaning without blame or defensiveness
- adjust tone and body language to support verbal clarity
- respond to misunderstandings in ways that protect trust and strengthen collaboration

Signals a Misunderstanding May Be Happening

A misunderstanding may be developing when you notice:

- silence or hesitation
- defensiveness
- confusion
- awkward pauses
- tension in tone
- short or withdrawn responses
- a reaction that does not match your intention

These signals do not always mean conflict, but they can be helpful cues to pause and check in.

Repair Language Can Help

Repair language helps you create clarity when your message did not land the way you intended. It is not about taking blame. It is about reopening understanding.

Examples include:

- Let me rephrase that.
- I do not think I said that clearly.
- That did not come out the way I intended.
- Can I try that again?
- I think we may be hearing this differently.
- Can we pause and reset?
- Can you tell me what you heard?

Tone and Body Language Matter

Your words are only one part of communication. People also interpret:

- tone of voice
- facial expression
- pacing
- eye contact
- posture
- gestures
- pauses

In multicultural workplaces, these cues may be understood differently by different people. Staying aware of this can help you avoid assumptions and approach misunderstandings with curiosity.
ifference.

Helpful Mindsets

When a misunderstanding happens, it can help to remember:

- misunderstandings are common
- clarity is more useful than blame
- repair is a shared process
- curiosity builds connection
- small check-ins can prevent bigger problems

A Simple Approach to Repair

When communication starts to break down:

1. **Pause** → Notice the signal.
2. **Clarify** → Rephrase your meaning more clearly.
3. **Check in** → Invite the other person's understanding.
4. **Adjust** → Use a tone and body language that match your intention.

Final Reflection

Repairing misunderstandings is an important part of building trust at work. The goal is not perfect communication. The goal is to notice when something is off, respond with care, and create clarity together.

One small repair can make a big difference.